

Inspection of Middlesbrough local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 8 to 19 June 2026

Lead inspector: Nabeel Hussain, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Requires improvement to be good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Requires improvement to be good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Requires improvement to be good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Requires improvement to be good

Since the previous inspection, the experiences of children and families in Middlesbrough have been significantly impacted by prolonged instability in senior leadership and a lack of previous corporate support. Over a short period of time, four directors of children's services (DCS) have led the service, and this churn in leadership has prevented the development of a clear strategic vision and the infrastructure needed to improve outcomes for children and families.

While turbulence in leadership has stalled the improvement of some services, there are pockets of stronger practice. Committed social workers, managers and practitioners continue to secure positive experiences for some children and care leavers. However, overall, the quality of help, protection and care remains too inconsistent. Too many children do not yet receive the timely, well-coordinated support they need. With a stable and experienced leadership team now in place, strategic planning and decision-making are improving, with clearer priorities and expectations beginning to drive more consistent practice.

What needs to improve?¹

- The extent to which leaders and the workforce are aspirational and ambitious for children in Middlesbrough while enabling children, young people and their families to actively shape service improvements through participation, engagement and influence. (enabler: leaders drive conditions for effective practice, national framework)
- The quality of written records for children, young people and families. (enabler: the workforce is equipped and effective, national framework)
- The identification and quality of support to young carers. (outcome 1, national framework)
- The quality and impact of management supervision in progressing children's assessments and plans, including decision-making for children entering care. (outcome 2, national framework)
- The exploration and engagement of family networks for children in need of help, care and protection. (outcome 3, national framework)
- The impact of challenge and escalation from independent reviewing officers, including the timeliness of children receiving permanence and life-story work. (outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: requires improvement to be good

1. Since the previous inspection, some children in need of help and protection have continued to receive effective support from committed social workers, practitioners and managers despite turbulent senior leadership.
2. Children in need of targeted early help receive a prompt response. Assessments are detailed and incorporate information from parents, professionals and family networks. Children's voices are captured through purposeful direct work and are used to inform their plans. Children's plans are reviewed regularly in supervision between managers and early help practitioners. For most children, this leads to improved outcomes and progress.
3. When risks escalate, children's circumstances are appropriately stepped up to statutory services for an assessment of their needs. Conversely, when needs decrease, effective step-down arrangements are in place. Thresholds are clearly understood and consistently applied. Contacts in the multi-agency children's hub (MACH) are usually progressed in a timely manner and are supported by proportionate enquiries.

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

4. Parental engagement in the MACH is explored at the earliest opportunity, with views recorded clearly. This is an improvement since the focused visit in December 2025. Family support networks are increasingly considered and used to support immediate safety planning. This ensures that the views of parents, carers and family networks are used to inform decisions for children.
5. Contacts that do not meet the threshold for early help are not recorded electronically, restricting practitioners' access to children's histories. This impacts on their analysis of children's lived experiences. Leaders were appropriately responsive to this finding during the inspection and made immediate changes to the process. Partner agencies appropriately re-refer when safeguarding concerns arise.
6. The daily domestic abuse and missing triage has been strengthened since the focused visit in December 2025. The specialist domestic abuse worker in the MACH adds value to the screening process where domestic abuse is a feature. These enquiries are thorough, consider history and routinely evidence how parents and carers are engaged early to develop their understanding of risks. Police referrals are mostly timely, enabling prompt responses from the MACH. While the quality of referral information can vary, discussions with partner agencies are collaborative, and professionals are curious about the impact of incidents on children's lives.
7. Management oversight is present at the start and end of contacts, although quality varies. Some oversight is generic and does not reflect children's individual experiences or previous referral history. Consequently, not all children's records demonstrate that managers fully consider referral information when signing off contacts.
8. The operational interface between the emergency duty team (EDT) and daytime services is effective. However, strategy meetings out of hours are not always held in a timely way due to a lack of availability of police colleagues. While no detriment was seen to children as EDT workers took appropriate safeguarding action, this is not in line with local procedures and guidance. Leaders have appropriate plans in place to address this. In contrast, strategy meetings held in working hours are well attended by relevant partners, and most strategy meetings lead to clear and proportionate outcomes.
9. Most child protection enquiries are purposeful and consider the need for an initial child protection conference (ICPC). For some children, there are delays in an ICPC being convened. When this happens, child protection chairs and team managers do not always reflect on the reasons for this through their required oversight. Detriment is mitigated by social workers who visit children between the child protection enquiry and the ICPC.
10. Statutory assessments of children's needs are mostly completed on time and include the contribution of parents, carers and multi-agency partners. Fathers and absent parents are routinely included in children's assessments. Most

assessments reflect children's identity, culture and uniqueness. Social workers use creative methods to engage children, including those who are non-verbal. The needs of individual children are recognised and considered alongside the needs of their brothers and sisters.

11. The needs of disabled children and their families are very well understood by social workers. Children access appropriate short breaks through early help and statutory pathways.
12. While pre-birth assessments increasingly show a clearer understanding of the cumulative impact of neglect experienced by older brothers and sisters, previous changes of social workers have disrupted continuity of understanding of children's family histories. This has resulted in some missed opportunities to deliver targeted interventions for some children sooner.
13. When children are supported by child protection plans, most core group meetings are regular and well attended by multi-agency partners. While they share information, this does not always lead to children's plans being detailed enough, nor do they reflect the individual needs of all children in the household. Family networks are not always explored or used to harness safety and support for children at the earliest opportunity. Similarly, contingency plans do not always reflect the engagement of non-resident parents or extended family members.
14. Child protection chairs routinely complete mid-way reviews during child protection planning, but their oversight is often compliance focused. When practice shortfalls are identified, formal escalation processes are not used consistently or effectively enough to enable frontline managers to support progress against children's plans.
15. Children are seen regularly by their social workers, and many enjoy warm, trusting relationships that help them to reach out when something is worrying them. However, the recording of these visits does not always capture the impact of the visit or the quality of the social work intervention against the child's plan. As such, records do not always demonstrate progress or improvements in the child's circumstances.
16. When child protection planning is not achieving positive change for children, appropriate action is taken to initiate the Public Law Outline (PLO). Tracking of PLO cases has improved significantly since the last inspection. Legal advice is sought promptly and actions are clearly recorded. Letters before proceedings outline concerns, expectations and the support available to families.
17. The local authority designated officer provides an effective response to allegations against adults working with children. Processes are clear, with appropriate multi-agency discussions and regular review of actions.
18. Systems to identify children missing education (CME) are robust. Strategies to re-engage children are often effective and have resulted in a reduction of CME

since the last inspection. Staff consider a range of factors influencing absence and elective home education, building positive relationships with families. Statutory duties are used when necessary to improve outcomes.

19. Children at risk of harm outside the home receive specialist support from practitioners in the Aspire team. Social workers in the Aspire team are persistent, creative and highly skilled in engaging children involved in exploitation. However, changes in workers mean that some children must retell their stories. This impacts on their ability to build stable, trusting relationships with workers. Leaders are aware of this and have credible plans in place to develop and achieve stability in the Aspire team.
20. Children who are reported as missing from home or care are identified promptly. Effective systems are in place to ensure that the circumstances surrounding the episode of going missing are explored by multi-agency professionals, including through repeat strategy meetings in line with escalating risk. Practitioners do not differentiate between missing-from-care episodes and occasions where children are absent without authorisation. The risks linked to absenteeism are not always recognised, leading to delays in early intervention and potential safeguarding responses.
21. Since the last inspection, a new homelessness protocol for 16 and 17-year-olds has been developed with the local authority housing service. This protocol is very recent and it is too early to see the impact of this on young people. Some children are prematurely assessed in line with the homelessness pathway, rather than receiving edge of care support. Positively, while the edge of care offer is not yet fully developed, some social work positions have been recently recruited to, and long-term workforce planning is underway.
22. Since the last inspection, improvements have been made in the identification and assessment of children living in private fostering arrangements. Visits and assessments are thorough and consider the views of the child. The panel process and dedicated independent reviewing officer (IRO) oversight provides scrutiny and approval of arrangements. The move to the kinship care service has meant that private foster carers now have access to the same level of support and training that all kinship carers have.
23. Not all young carers are identified promptly. For those who are, assessments and plans do not explicitly consider the impact of the child's caring responsibilities on their development and wellbeing. There are no bespoke services for young carers. Consequently, opportunities for respite and emotional and practical support are limited.

The experiences and progress of children in care: requires improvement to be good

24. The quality of management oversight when children enter care has weakened since the last inspection. Some children do not initially experience the most

appropriate placement match, and some children should have entered care sooner.

25. When children do enter care, the assessments of their needs are comprehensive and child focused. A small number of assessments were exemplary. In these examples, the unique needs and attributes of children were captured and celebrated. Impressive social workers use tools and research thoughtfully to encourage the exploration of culture, identity, diversity and adultification.
26. Assessments for children in care are not always updated following significant events. As such, they do not always accurately reflect the current needs or experiences of children in care. Family networks are explored routinely but they are not always used to their full potential.
27. Once identified, children are supported to remain with their extended family and kinship carers, following thorough assessments. For most children, these arrangements are regulated and carers are provided with the support they need to safely look after children. Children's wishes and interests are usually at the centre of these arrangements and their support plans.
28. Most children in care living away from Middlesbrough continue to receive support from their social worker in line with their needs. Visits are regular and children's views are listened to and used to inform decisions about children's care. Long-term fostering is a strength, with children well matched to carers who know them well and offer consistent, stable relationships.
29. The recruitment of foster carers has not kept pace with the rising number of children needing care. Leaders have a clear understanding of the resulting shortfall. Recruitment events are planned and already have increased enquiries, although vacancies and sickness within the team are impacting currently on caseloads and the timeliness of some work. Despite these pressures, committed social workers complete thorough assessments of carers, who consistently report positive experiences of the support they receive. Workforce uncertainties are currently evident and understandable in the fostering service as staff await clarity on how regional care cooperatives may affect future roles and arrangements. Senior leaders are managing this well, and communication to staff has been open, transparent and focused on supporting the workforce while national and regional plans evolve.
30. Leaders have very recently introduced tracking arrangements to maintain oversight of children living in unregistered, illegal placements. These placements are only used when other options have been exhausted. While in its infancy, the tracker is effective and is supporting leaders' line of sight. This process has identified shortfalls in the frequency of visits to some children in unregistered settings, which senior leaders are addressing.

31. While the commitment of IROs to children and their role is clear, the quality of records and the extent to which they challenge poor practice is inconsistent. The formal dispute resolution process is used infrequently and lacks rigour. The frequency and intensity of challenge from IROs does not always increase in line with risks to children. Similarly, not all records evidence how IROs close the loop following a challenge. This reduces their ability to meaningfully track the child's progress and activate the formal dispute resolution process effectively if there is a disagreement over a child's plan.
32. When children in care are at risk, strategy meetings are timely and include contributions from multi-agency partners. While the outcomes of these meetings are proportionate, children with the most complex needs are allocated to a single agency worker. There is a vulnerability around the stability of this arrangement for the children and the associated demands on the worker.
33. Most children experience safe, purposeful family time that supports their identity and relationships. Records of family time are detailed and analytical. The capacity of resource workers in this service limits the quality and consistency of their input into assessments for children in care. Leaders are aware of this and have plans to increase capacity in this service.
34. Managers have introduced regular permanence tracking arrangements. Despite this, the prominence and timeliness of permanence planning for children is inconsistent, with some children's records not referring to, or reflecting on, plans for their permanence. Minutes from tracking meetings are not detailed enough, nor do they demonstrate how and by when permanence will be achieved for children. This is impacting on the effectiveness of permanency planning for children.
35. There are strong relationships between the regional adoption agency and the local authority. This ensures effective panels and well-coordinated support for children and their adoptive families. Children are well matched with their adopters, giving them the foundations they need to thrive in their new families. Adopters value the support and high-quality training they receive from their supervising social workers, which helps them to feel confident and well prepared to become parents. Introductions are carefully managed, with children and adopters benefiting from skilled workers who guide them through each stage. Not all children or their adopters benefit from life-story work, which means children are not helped to understand their histories or the reason for their adoption.
36. The number of children achieving permanence through special guardianship orders (SGOs) is gradually increasing. While not all children achieve permanence through SGOs in a timely way, when this does happen, assessments and support plans are of sufficient quality. Special guardians are supported financially and practically with safety plans to assist them in managing family time arrangements.

37. Most children reunified with their parents benefit from thorough and proportionate assessments of risk. Children's views are considered alongside parenting capacity to inform these decisions. However, not all arrangements are considered in looked after reviews thereafter. Consequently, the quality of support for children reunified with their parents is not explicitly evaluated or reviewed.
38. Children in care receive appropriate support to ensure that their physical health and emotional wellbeing needs are met. The designated looked-after children's nurse progresses referrals and offers advice and strategies to support children in their placements. When children require additional support to manage their emotions or understand their needs relating to neurodiversity, private therapy or assessments are commissioned.
39. Support for unaccompanied asylum-seeking children is excellent. However, it is dependent on the practice of one single agency worker. Consequently, there is an absence of understanding across the wider workforce relating to children's unique needs, trauma, identity, ethnicity and culture. Children have advocates so that their voice can be independently heard, and workers promote early appointments of legal representation so that their leave to remain can be heard at the earliest opportunity.
40. Schools and settings highly value the support provided by the virtual school. Staff respond promptly to any concerns identified, such as reduced attendance, lower educational outcomes or suspensions. Leaders have established clear structures to ensure that children's educational needs, as well as their wider development, are supported effectively. For some children, targets in their personal education plans do not consistently identify the specific actions required to support progress. This makes it difficult to evaluate the impact of identified actions. Despite this, leaders and staff are responsive to children's needs and step in to address these when required.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: requires improvement to be good

41. Until recently, care leavers have not benefited from a service with strong management oversight, clear staff guidance or sustained resources. This has impacted on the extent to which care leavers have felt supported, enabled and held. When current senior leaders were appointed, they were proactive in commissioning a peer review of the Pathways service. While the findings offered a largely accurate assessment of the quality and impact of support provided to care leavers, the more recent absence of a permanent senior manager has hindered the implementation of the review's recommendations.
42. Not all care leavers receive an appropriate, considered and planned transition into the service or are introduced to their personal adviser (PA) early enough to build a relationship. As such, some experience anxiety about their next steps.

Similarly, when care leavers need support from adult services, not all have had their needs assessed in a timely way.

43. Despite turbulence within the service, some care leavers have benefited from a stable, trusted and consistent relationship with committed PAs who know the needs of their young people well. They offer support that is purposeful and enables care leavers to make progress. Most PAs visit care leavers regularly. They recognise and value the importance of special occasions, such as birthdays, and many PAs reach out in celebration. This is not the experience of all care leavers.
44. When care leavers experience challenges with their mental health, services are available to offer support. While there is evidence of PAs communicating with partners via email and telephone, at times this can be reactive and in response to acute crisis. Multi-agency professionals do not always come together regularly or in a planned way to agree the most appropriate plan of support for care leavers.
45. Some care leavers' records make explicit reference to the local offer, detailing their rights and entitlements. Likewise, in some pathway plans, elements of the local offer were routinely included for care leavers to reference and utilise.
46. Pathway plans completed by PAs are more thorough than those completed in the children in care service. PAs ensure that they have a detailed understanding of the unique needs and challenges faced by care leavers and reflect this in their plans. Many pathway plans are comprehensive, detailed and clearly demonstrate the voice and contribution of care leavers, but some lack aspiration for care leavers' futures. Although the role of professionals involved are detailed in plans, their contribution is not always clear. Pathway plans are not always updated following significant events and therefore are not always relevant to a care leaver's current circumstances.
47. Disabled care leavers receive purposeful and coordinated support from their PAs and professionals in health and adult services. Not all plans for disabled care leavers reflect the impact of their disability and how this affects them in their daily life.
48. Decisions to continue services post-21 are taken in discussion with care leavers and informed by their presenting needs. This is an improvement from the last inspection. For some care leavers, PAs make conscious and deliberate efforts to build the young person's independence as they approach 21. This is encouraging independent decision-making while maintaining the support of the PA. Allocation decisions are sensitive, with some older care leavers up to the age of 25 still benefiting from the continuity of the trusting relationship they have developed with their PA.
49. When a care leaver is to be closed to the service, managers provide appropriate oversight and challenge. This offers assurance that identified needs, including

contingency planning, are considered. Similarly, care leavers are informed of how and who to contact should they require support in the future.

50. Not all care leavers at risk receive appropriate and timely responses by PAs. Most PAs share information with multi-agency partners and act promptly where there is an immediate risk. For some care leavers, PAs and managers were less decisive, and the impact of coordinated multi-agency responses was less clear.
51. Most care leavers are living in safe and suitable accommodation. Staying put is appropriately considered when it is in the young person's best interests. This supports significant and important relationships being maintained. Care leavers in custody continue to receive support and have plans that meet their needs. PAs have established monthly drop-in sessions at youth offending settings, which offers an additional opportunity to assess care leavers' wellbeing and plan for release. PAs recognise and support the additional vulnerability of care leavers who are parents and support them through child protection planning or care proceedings.
52. The extent to which care leavers are routinely supported to access ID documents and records is not always clear. This, coupled with an absence of life-story work, impacts on the ability of young people to understand and process their histories.
53. PAs appreciate the recent improved stability within the team. Team managers recognise the strengths in the workforce, such as PAs holding previous roles within the police and exploitation services. This supports care leavers in being allocated PAs who are skilled and experienced to meet their needs.
54. Management oversight following a significant event is mostly clear and well documented in care leavers' records. While case supervision was mostly regular, some PAs shared they had not received personal supervision at a frequency that meets their needs.
55. The virtual school ensures that designated teachers and staff routinely consider decisions to support care leavers to successfully move on to post-16 education and training pathways. Despite this, there are a significant proportion of care leavers who are not in education, employment or training. Leaders demonstrate the ambition to improve this. However, there is no clearly established strategy to bring about sustained improvement in this area. This prevents the local authority from anticipating possible barriers to education, employment and training at the earliest possible opportunity.
56. While training and development opportunities are available, not all PAs are clear on how to access the pathway, particularly for more specialist training. Leaders have plans in place to strengthen and enhance the existing training offer. PAs shared that the recently introduced workforce briefings and team check-ins are starting to make them feel listened to and included. Several practitioners

expressed the need to improve the dedicated hub for care leavers. This is something leaders are aware of and are keen to progress.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: requires improvement to be good

57. Since the last inspection, the significant turnover of DCS and senior leaders has impacted on the quality and consistency of services for children in Middlesbrough. As such, one of the current DCS' key priorities has been to achieve stability within the senior leadership team.
58. With the support of the council's corporate and finance teams, the DCS has very recently recruited 2 experienced and permanent service directors from within the region, bringing much-needed stability and experience. The prolonged turbulence caused by senior leadership changes has left instability across other layers of management across the service, which the DCS is beginning to address.
59. The substantial turnover in senior leaders has had a significant impact, stalling improvement and disrupting the continuity needed to drive progress in some areas of children's services. As a result, the current DCS has had to focus first on stabilising the service, strengthening key safeguarding functions and rebuilding confidence across both the partnership and the workforce. These necessary stabilisation efforts mean that leaders have not yet been able to turn their full attention to developing the wider social care reforms. They are acutely aware of this and the importance of progressing it now they have a permanent senior leadership team.
60. The DCS is taking a methodical and systematic approach towards improvement and has been proactive in forging collaborative relationships with her regional peers. She is keen to shape a culture where Middlesbrough is outward facing and open to learning from other local authorities.
61. Historically, financial pressures in the council resulted in cuts being made across vital services. This has had a direct influence on the accuracy and impact of quality assurance processes, which became diluted and weakened. Strategic decision-making across the council was not child focused, nor did it hold children's experiences at the centre. Current executive and political leaders were already aware of this and have ensured that the DCS and her leadership team have the full commitment and support of the wider council. There is a commitment to doing things differently, and leaders are clear that every child in Middlesbrough deserves consistent, high-quality support. Achieving this is now a top priority for leaders, not only in children's services but across the council as a whole.
62. The chief executive and lead member have very recently strengthened their oversight and scrutiny through attending the improvement board established by the current DCS in February 2026. The board benefits from an independent

chair, who is a former DCS, and the Local Government Association's regional children's improvement adviser. The improvement board has illuminated the scale of the challenge ahead, which executive and political leaders were not previously aware of. As such, leaders are now being supported to move towards a culture of seeking assurance through evidence rather than reassurance based on feeling or opinion.

63. The current DCS has been central to developing a renewed relationship with the sector-led improvement partner, who now contributes to the improvement board, resulting in a sharper focus on strengthening the quality and impact of services for children. The current improvement plan, while in its infancy, is coherent and benefits from corporate and financial backing.
64. Feedback from both Cafcass and the judiciary highlights a recent improvement in the quality of social work practice, with stronger analysis, clearer planning and more confident decision-making.
65. While performance and quality assurance mechanisms are in place, they are not yet mature or fully embedded. A significant proportion of plans and strategy meetings are coded inaccurately and require particular attention. This is affecting the accuracy of leaders' line of sight into practice. Leaders were able to show how they plan to strengthen the acquisition and analysis of data and had already commenced some of this prior to this inspection. This has been effective and is having a positive impact. Recent audits are child focused, comprehensive, well written and evidence based.
66. The local authority's engagement with the local safeguarding children's partnership has been too limited. This has contributed to delays in achieving a coherent and purposeful multi-agency strategic plan for children. Leaders are aware of this, and there is an appetite to strengthen presence once the senior management team is fully established in the coming weeks.
67. There is limited evidence that young people have been routinely consulted about service developments, celebrated for their achievements or that their successes have been recognised and promoted by corporate parents. Similarly, opportunities for children and young people are limited, both in the council and in their communities.
68. Several practitioners described a culture of low expectations for some of Middlesbrough's children. This narrative has become accepted by some staff, limiting ambition and aspiration for young people. Leaders acknowledge their role in addressing this narrative and recognise their responsibility to challenge and change it.
69. The local authority faces the same placement sufficiency challenges seen nationally and regionally. Leaders are taking a proactive approach, strengthening local options, and have a strong focus on developing high-quality in-house provision. The recent and improved quality of in-house residential

homes is a standout strength. Despite this, too many very young children continue to live in residential care as a result of previous weaknesses in planning and sufficiency. Leaders are aware of this, and have credible plans in place to make the required improvements.

70. Considerable sufficiency challenges have resulted in some children living in unsuitable accommodation, including unregulated, illegal placements. Leaders have very recently introduced tracking arrangements to maintain oversight of children in these arrangements. While in its infancy, the tracker is proving to be effective and is supporting leaders' oversight and line of sight. Leaders have credible plans in place to increase sufficiency, but many of these are in their infancy and have not yet been executed.
71. Leaders are in the very early stages of understanding the needs of children and staff from global majority backgrounds. Consequently, there is a current gap in understanding across the workforce on how children from diverse backgrounds should be supported. However, there are plans in place for this to be meaningfully explored and understood.
72. Practitioners across children's social care teams feel supported and listened to by their managers. Most shared how supervision is regular, with managers paying particular attention to staff wellbeing. Staff shared how the current DCS and her leadership team have taken the time to pause, listen and consult with them as part of the planned improvements. Several agency workers have made a deliberate decision to apply for permanent positions. This is largely and significantly influenced by the change in culture being promoted by the current leadership team.
73. While frequent changes in leadership have left staff feeling fatigued, there is a tangible and growing sense of hope and optimism across the workforce.

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